Bill's Helix Cheat Sheet / Command Reference

1 Introduction

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Distributed at GitHub
https://github.com/wrwetzel/helix
https://helix.wrwetzel.com
Based on Helix version: 25.07.1.
https://helix-editor.com/
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1.1 Definitions

- **file** - the actual data on storage device
- **buffers** - data from one or more files loaded into memory
- **view** - one or more visual areas on screen showing one or more buffers
- **workspace** - the directory from which Helix was launched
- **under selection** - the entire word containing the cursor, not just the selection
- **alternate buffer** - the previous active buffer
- **textual line** - text as defined by the newline character
- **visual line** - what appears on screen after word-wrapping

1.2 Typographic Conventions

- **`word`** - alphanumeric, punctuation-delimited
- **`WORD`** - whitespace-delimited
- **`Ctrl-c`** - Ctrl and c key pressed simultaneous.
- **`Alt-c`** - Alt and c key pressed simultaneous.
- Metavars **`<regex>`**, **`<file>`** and **`<ch>`** represent user input. The angle-brackets are not part of the command.
- **`␣c`** is space followed by the character c.
- Commands are separated from definitions by a dash. Synonyms are separated by commas. Related commands are separated by slashes. The separators are never part of the command though commands may include a dash, comma, or slash.
- Some Alt and Ctrl characters may conflict with terminal capture and require terminal configuration change.
- **`␣`**, **`<minus>`**, and **`<under>`** used for clarity. **`<enter>`**, **`<del>`**, **`<bksp>`**, etc. used for non-printing control characters.

1.3 Launching

- **`helix`**
- **`helix`** `<file>`
- **`helix`** `<file1> <file2> … <filen>`
- **`helix`** `–help`
- **`hx`** `in some distributions or by alias`

1.4 Basics

Editing paradigm: select first, action second. *mode* and *count* are optional.

```
[mode][count][select][command]
```

1.4.1 Example

```
v3wd
          v – enter select mode
          3 – select 3
          w – words
          d – delete
```

1.4.2 Samples

```
         wd – delete word
         xc – change line
         %y – yank entire file
```

1.5 Modes

As used in Helix documentation.

```
          : – command
          i – insert
          v – select or extend
          z – view - change view preserving
              selection
          g – goto
          m – match
     Ctrl-w – window
          ␣ – space
       [, ] – unimpaired
```

2 Primary Commands

2.1 Essentials

`u / U`	undo / redo change in linear history
`Alt-u / Alt-U`	move backward / forward in tree history
`:ear / :lat`	move backward / forward in history by step count or time span (1s, 2m, 3h, 4d)
`<nn><cmd>`	repeat <cmd> <nn> times
`Esc`	return to normal mode

2.1.1 Quit

Add **!** suffix to force operation.

`:wq`	write current buffer and quit
`:wq <file>`	write current buffer to <file> and quit
`:wqa`	write all buffer(s) and quit
`:q`	quit current buffer, exits if last

2.1.2 Files

`:o <file>`	open <file> in new buffer
`:w <file>`	write current buffer to <file>
`:hs <file>`	open/create <file> in new horizontal split
`:vs <file>`	open/create <file> in new vertical split
`␣wf`	open/create file(s) under selection(s) in horizontal split
`␣wF`	open/create file(s) under selection(s) in vertical split
`gf`	open/create file(s) under selection, open url under selection.
`␣f`	open file picker at LSP workspace root
`␣F`	open file picker at current working directory
`␣g`	open changed file picker

2.1.2.1 File Picker

All pickers, here and elsewhere, are *fuzzy* - they tolerate gaps in the input, ranking closer matches higher.

`<enter>`	open selected in current view
`Ctrl-s`	open selected in new horizontal split
`Ctrl-v`	open selected in new vertical split

2.1.3 Buffers

Add **!** suffix to force operation. Buffers named by file they contain.

`:n`	create new scratch buffer
`:bc`	close current buffer
`:bca`	close all buffers
`:bco`	close all but current buffer
`:bn`	next buffer
`␣b`	open buffer picker
`ga`	go to last accessed/alternate buffer
`gm`	go to last modified/alternate buffer
`gn`	go to next buffer
`gp`	go to previous buffer

2.1.4 Views

Ctrl-w and `␣w` are synonymous.

`␣ws / ␣wv`	split horizontal / vertical, current buffer
`␣wns / ␣wnv`	split horizontal / vertical, new buffer
`␣wq`	close current split
`␣wo`	close all but current split
`␣ww`	next split
`␣wh/j/k/l`	move to buffer left / up / down / right
`␣wH/J/K/L`	swap split with buffer on left / up / down / right
`␣wt`	transpose split

2.1.4.1 View Movement

Commands shown with **z** prefix. The prefix is not used in sticky mode, which is a view-only navigation mode appropriate for browsing a file without editing.

`Z`	enter sticky mode, exit with Esc
`zz, zc`	align to center
`zt`	align to top
`zb`	align to bottom
`zm`	align to middle horizontally
`zj`	scroll down
`zk`	scroll up

2.1.5 Help

`:tutor`	open tutorial
`␣?`	open command palette

2.2 Movement

2.2.1 Cursor Movement

Normal Mode: motion replaces selection
Select Mode: motion extends selection

`h/j/k/l`	left / up / down / right
`gh, g|`	beginning of line
`<nn>g|`	column <nn>
`gl`	end of line
`gg`	top of file
`<nn>G,`	line <nn>
`g<nn>g`	
`ge`	bottom of file
`gw`	two-char labels on words, label to go to word
`g.`	to last modification in current file
`gj`	down textual line
`gk`	up textual line
`gs`	first non-white-space char
`gt`	top of screen
`gc`	middle of screen
`gb`	bottom of screen

2.2.2 By Language Server Protocol - Semantics

Requires LSP support.

`gd`	go to definition
`gy`	go to type definition
`gr`	go to references
`gi`	go to implementation
`]d`	next diagnostic
`[d`	prior diagnostic
`]D`	last diagnostic
`[D`	first diagnostic

2.2.3 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

`]f, [f`	to next, prior function
`]t, [t`	to next, prior type definition
`]T, [T`	to next, prior test
`]a, [a`	to next, prior arg
`]c, [c`	to next, prior comment
`]g, [g`	to next, prior change
`]G, [G`	to last, first change
`Alt-e`	move to end of parent node in syntax tree
`Alt-b`	move to start of parent node in syntax tree

2.2.4 By Page

`Ctrl-b`	page up
`Ctrl-f`	page down
`Ctrl-u`	half page up
`Ctrl-d`	half page down

2.3 Selection

Selection: a range of characters between anchor and cursor
Normal Mode: move and select
Select Mode: move and extend selection

2.3.1 Operations

`%`	select whole file
`Alt-;`	swap anchor and cursor
`Alt-:`	selection to normal direction (cursor at end)
`Alt-o`	expand selection syntax-aware
`Alt-i`	shrink selection
`;`	collapse selection(s) to cursor(s)

2.3.2 By TextObjects

`ma<ch> / mi<ch>`	match around / inside the object indicated by <ch> below:
`w / W`	word / WORD
`p`	paragraph
`(, [, ', etc.`	specified surround pairs
`m`	closest surround pair
`f`	function
`t`	type or class
`a`	argument/parameter
`c`	comment
`T`	test
`g`	change git hunk

2.3.3 By Syntactic Objects

`w / W`	to start of next word / WORD
`e / E`	to end of current word / WORD
`b / B`	to start of current word / WORD
`x`	current line, extend by line
`X`	extend to line
`Alt-x`	shrink to line bounds
`]p`	to next paragraph
`[p`	to prior paragraph

2.3.4 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

`Alt-o`	expand selection to parent syntax node
`Alt-i`	shrink syntax tree object selection
`Alt-p`	select previous sibling node in syntax tree
`Alt-n`	select next sibling node in syntax tree
`Alt-a`	select all sibling nodes in syntax tree
`Alt-I`	select all children nodes in syntax tree

2.3.5 By Character Value

Lower case: forward
Upper case: backward

`f<ch>, F<ch>`	to <ch> inclusive (find)
`t<ch>, T<ch>`	to <ch> exclusive (till)
`Alt-.`	repeat last find / till

2.4 Select Mode

Movement: extends selection
Search: adds to selection

`v`	toggle select mode
`Esc`	return to normal
`)`	cycle primary selection forward
`(`	cycle primary selection backward
`Alt-,`	remove primary selection

2.5 Multiple Selections

Multiple independent cursors / selections, one is *primary*.

2.5.1 Creating

Create multiple selections from selection.

`s<regex>`	matches become selections
`S`	split on match
`Alt-s`	split on newlines
`C, Alt-C`	add selection below, above

2.5.2 Operations

`&`	align on primary cursor
`Alt-<minus>`	merge selections
`Alt-<under>`	merge consecutive selections
`,`	remove all except primary selection
`Alt-,`	remove primary selection
`( / )`	rotate primary backwards / forwards
`Alt-( / Alt-)`	rotate content backward / forward
`K`	keep selections matching the regex
`Alt-K`	remove selections matching the regex

2.6 Alter Buffer Content

2.6.1 Insert

`i`	before selection
`a`	after selection
`I`	at start of line
`A`	at end of line
`o`	add line and insert below cursor
`O`	add line and insert above cursor
`Esc`	end insert (return to normal)
`.`	repeat last insert

2.6.2 Add

`]␣`	newline below
`[␣`	newline above
`ms<ch>`	add delim <ch> around selection

2.6.3 Delete

`d`	selection -> yank buf, delete selection
`Alt-d`	delete, no save
`md<ch>`	delete delim <ch> around selection

2.6.4 Change

`c`	selection -> yank buf, change selection
`Alt-c`	change, no save
`=`	format by LSP
`mr<ch1><ch2>`	replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>

2.6.5 Indent Lines

`>`	Indent line(s) containing selection
`<`	Undent line(s) containing selection

2.6.6 Change Case

Change case of all letters in selection

`~`	change case
`` ` ``	set lowercase
`Alt-` `	set uppercase

2.6.7 Comments

All apply to selection.

`␣c, Ctrl-c`	Toggle comment
`␣C`	Toggle block comment
`␣Alt-C`	Toggle line comment

2.6.8 Increment / Decrement

`Ctrl-a`	increment the selected number
`Ctrl-x`	decrement the selected number

2.6.9 Miscellaneous

`J`	join lines in a selection
`Alt-J`	join lines inside selection and select the inserted space
`<under>`	trim whitespace from selection

2.7 Copy / Paste / Replace

```
          y – selection -> yank buf
          p – paste yank buf after the cursor
          P – paste yank buf before the cursor
         ␣y – yank selection(s) -> system clipboard
         ␣Y – yank main selection -> system
              clipboard
     ␣p / ␣P – paste clipboard after / before
              selections(s)
         ␣R – replace selection(s) with clipboard
      r<ch> – replace selection with <ch>
          R – replace selection with yank buf
          " – select register to yank to or paste
              from
```

2.8 Search

```
    /<regex> – search forward for regex
    ?<regex> – search backward for regex
       n, N – next, previous match
          * – search for current selection, respect
              word boundaries
     Alt-* – search for current selection
```

2.9 Registers

Identified by single char <ch>

```
      "<ch> – change to reg <ch>
     "<ch>y – yank into reg <ch>
     "<ch>p – paste from reg <ch>
     "<ch>R – replace with reg <ch>
```

2.10 Macros

```
     "<ch>Q – toggle capture to reg <ch>, default @
     "<ch>q – play macro in reg <ch>, default @
```

2.11 Jumplists

```
     Ctrl-s – save current position to jumplist
     Ctrl-i – move forward in jumplist
     Ctrl-o – move backwards in jumplist
         ␣j – open jumplist picker
```

2.12 Match Mode

With regard to balanced delimiters.

```
            mm – go to matching delim
     mi<ch> – match inside delim <ch>
     ma<ch> – match around delim <ch>
     ms<ch> – add delim <ch> around
              selection
     md<ch> – delete delim <ch> around
              selection
mr<ch1><ch2> – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>
```

2.13 Shell

All commands pipe each selection to shell command.

```
          | – replace selection(s) with output
     Alt-| – ignore output
          ! – insert output before each
              selection(s)
     Alt-! – append output after each
              selection(s)
          $ – keep selection(s) where command
              returned 0
```

2.14 Approaching an IDE

```
         ␣G – debug - experimental
         ␣k – show documentation for item under
              cursor
         ␣s – open document symbol picker
         ␣S – open workspace symbol picker
         ␣d – open document diagnostics picker
         ␣D – open workspace diagnostics picker
         ␣r – rename symbol
         ␣a – apply code action
         ␣h – select symbol references for symbol
              under cursor
```

2.15 Editor Configuration

```
     :config-open – open the config file
  :config-open-– open the workspace
       workspace  config file
  :config-reload – reload the config file
```

2.16 Miscellaneous

```
         ␣' – open last picker
         ␣/ – open global search in workspace
              folder picker
```

3 Commands in Specific Contexts

3.1 Insert Mode Editing

Navigation keys shown.

Ctrl-s	commit undo checkpoint
Ctrl-x	autocomplete
Ctrl-r	insert a register content
Ctrl-w, Alt-<bksp>	delete previous word
Alt-d, Alt-<del>	delete next word
Ctrl-u	delete to start of line
Ctrl-k	delete to end of line
Ctrl-h, <bksp>, Shift-<bksp>	delete previous char
Ctrl-d, <del>	delete next char
Ctrl-j, <enter>	insert new line
<Up> <Down> <Left> <Right> <PageUp> <PageDown> <Home> <End>	usual meaning but discouraged

3.2 Command Line Editing

Esc, Ctrl-c	close prompt
<enter>	open selected
<tab>	select next completion item
<backtab>	select previous completion item
Alt-b	backward a word
Ctrl-b	backward a char
Alt-f	forward a word
Ctrl-f	forward a char
Ctrl-e	to prompt end
Ctrl-a	to prompt start
Ctrl-w, Ctrl-<bksp>	delete previous word
Alt-d, Ctrl-<del>	delete next word
Ctrl-u	delete to start of line
Ctrl-k	delete to end of line
<bksp>, Ctrl-h	delete previous char
<del>, Ctrl-d	delete next char
Ctrl-s	insert a word under doc cursor (may be changed to Ctrl-r Ctrl-w later)
Ctrl-p	select previous history
Ctrl-n	select next history
Ctrl-r	insert the content of the register selected by following input char

3.3 Pickers

Navigation keys shown.

Shift-<tab>, Ctrl-p, <Up>	previous entry
<tab>, Ctrl-n, <Down>	next entry
<Home>	to first entry
<End>	to last entry
Ctrl-u, <PageUp>	page up
Ctrl-d, <PageDown>	page down
<enter>	open selected
Alt-<enter>	open selected in the background without closing the picker
Ctrl-s	open horizontally
Ctrl-v	open vertically
Ctrl-t	toggle preview
Esc, Ctrl-c	close picker

3.4 Popups

Displays documentation for item under cursor.

Ctrl-u	scroll up
Ctrl-d	scroll down

3.5 Completion Menu

Displays documentation for the selected completion item. Any other keypresses result in the completion being accepted.

Shift-Tab, Ctrl-p	previous entry
Tab, Ctrl-n	next entry
<enter>	close menu and accept completion
Ctrl-c	close menu and reject completion

3.6 Signature-help Popup

Displays the signature of the selected completion item.

Alt-p	previous signature
Alt-n	next signature

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Ctrl-h – delete previous char (3.1)
Ctrl-h – delete previous char (3.2)
Ctrl-i – move forward in jumplist (2.11)
Ctrl-j – insert new line (3.1)
Ctrl-k – delete to end of line (3.1)
Ctrl-k – delete to end of line (3.2)
Ctrl-n – next entry (3.3)
Ctrl-n – next entry (3.5)
Ctrl-n – select next history (3.2)
Ctrl-o – move backwards in jumplist (2.11)
Ctrl-p – previous entry (3.3)
Ctrl-p – previous entry (3.5)
Ctrl-p – select previous history (3.2)
Ctrl-r – insert a register content (3.1)
Ctrl-r – insert the content of the register selected by following input char (3.2)
Ctrl-s – commit undo checkpoint (3.1)
Ctrl-s – insert a word under doc cursor (may be changed to Ctrl-r Ctrl-w later) (3.2)
Ctrl-s – open horizontally (3.3)
Ctrl-s – open selected in new horizontal split (2.1.2.1)

Ctrl-s – save current position to jumplist (2.11)
Ctrl-t – toggle preview (3.3)
Ctrl-u – delete to start of line (3.1)
Ctrl-u – delete to start of line (3.2)
Ctrl-u – half page up (2.2.4)
Ctrl-u – page up (3.3)
Ctrl-u – scroll up (3.4)
Ctrl-v – open selected in new vertical split (2.1.2.1)
Ctrl-v – open vertically (3.3)
Ctrl-w – delete previous word (3.1)
Ctrl-w – delete previous word (3.2)
Ctrl-x – autocomplete (3.1)
Ctrl-x – decrement the selected number (2.6.8)
Esc – close picker (3.3)
Esc – close prompt (3.2)
Esc – end insert (return to normal) (2.6.1)
Esc – return to normal (2.4)
Esc – return to normal mode (2.1)
F<ch> – to <ch> inclusive (find) (2.3.5)
I – at start of line (2.6.1)
J – join lines in a selection (2.6.9)
K – keep selections matching the regex (2.5.2)
N – next, previous match (2.8)
O – add line and insert above cursor (2.6.1)
P – paste yank buf before the cursor (2.7)
R – replace selection with yank buf (2.7)
S – split on match (2.5.1)
Shift-<bksp> – delete previous char (3.1)
Shift-<tab> – previous entry (3.3)
Shift-Tab – previous entry (3.5)
T – test (2.3.2)
T<ch> – to <ch> exclusive (till) (2.3.5)
Tab – next entry (3.5)
X – extend to line (2.3.3)
Z – enter sticky mode, exit with Esc (2.1.4.1)
[␣ – newline above (2.6.2)
[– specified surround pairs (2.3.2)
[D – first diagnostic (2.2.2)
[G – to last, first change (2.2.3)
[T – to next, prior test (2.2.3)
[a – to next, prior arg (2.2.3)
[c – to next, prior comment (2.2.3)
[d – prior diagnostic (2.2.2)

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[f  – to next, prior function (2.2.3)
[g  – to next, prior change (2.2.3)
[p  – to prior paragraph (2.3.3)
[t  – to next, prior type definition (2.2.3)
]␣  – newline below (2.6.2)
]D  – last diagnostic (2.2.2)
]G  – to last, first change (2.2.3)
]T  – to next, prior test (2.2.3)
]a  – to next, prior arg (2.2.3)
]c  – to next, prior comment (2.2.3)
]d  – next diagnostic (2.2.2)
]f  – to next, prior function (2.2.3)
]g  – to next, prior change (2.2.3)
]p  – to next paragraph (2.3.3)
]t  – to next, prior type definition (2.2.3)
`   – set lowercase (2.6.6)
a   – after selection (2.6.1)
a   – argument/parameter (2.3.2)
b / B – to start of current word / WORD
        (2.3.3)
c   – comment (2.3.2)
c   – selection -> yank buf, change
        selection (2.6.4)
d   – selection -> yank buf, delete
        selection (2.6.3)
e / E – to end of current word / WORD
        (2.3.3)
etc.– specified surround pairs (2.3.2)
f   – function (2.3.2)
f<ch> – to <ch> inclusive (find) (2.3.5)
g   – change git hunk (2.3.2)
g.  – to last modification in current file
        (2.2.1)
g<nn>g – line <nn> (2.2.1)
ga  – go to last accessed/alternate buffer
        (2.1.3)
gb  – bottom of screen (2.2.1)
gc  – middle of screen (2.2.1)
gd  – go to definition (2.2.2)
ge  – bottom of file (2.2.1)
gf  – open/create file(s) under selection,
        open url under selection. (2.1.2)
gg  – top of file (2.2.1)
gh  – beginning of line (2.2.1)
gi  – go to implementation (2.2.2)
gj  – down textual line (2.2.1)
gk  – up textual line (2.2.1)
gl  – end of line (2.2.1)
gm  – go to last modified/alternate buffer
        (2.1.3)
gn  – go to next buffer (2.1.3)
gp  – go to previous buffer (2.1.3)
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gr  – go to references (2.2.2)
gs  – first non-white-space char (2.2.1)
gt  – top of screen (2.2.1)
gw  – two-char labels on words, label to go
        to word (2.2.1)
gy  – go to type definition (2.2.2)
g|  – beginning of line (2.2.1)
h/j/k/l – left / up / down / right (2.2.1)
i   – before selection (2.6.1)
m   –  closest surround pair (2.3.2)
ma<ch> – match around delim <ch> (2.12)
ma<ch> / – match around / inside the object
mi<ch>     indicated by <ch> below: (2.3.2)
md<ch> – delete delim <ch> around selection
        (2.12)
md<ch> – delete delim <ch> around selection
        (2.6.3)
mi<ch> – match inside delim <ch> (2.12)
mm  – go to matching delim (2.12)
mr<ch1><ch2> – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2> (2.12)
mr<ch1><ch2> – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2> (2.6.4)
ms<ch> – add delim <ch> around selection
        (2.12)
ms<ch> – add delim <ch> around selection
        (2.6.2)
n   – next, previous match (2.8)
o   – add line and insert below cursor
        (2.6.1)
p   – paragraph (2.3.2)
p   – paste yank buf after the cursor (2.7)
r<ch> – replace selection with <ch> (2.7)
s<regex> – matches become selections (2.5.1)
t   – type or class (2.3.2)
t<ch> – to <ch> exclusive (till) (2.3.5)
u / U – undo / redo change in linear history
        (2.1)
v   – toggle select mode (2.4)
w / W – to start of next word / WORD (2.3.3)
w / W – word / WORD (2.3.2)
x   – current line, extend by line (2.3.3)
y   – selection -> yank buf (2.7)
zb  – align to bottom (2.1.4.1)
zc  – align to center (2.1.4.1)
zj  – scroll down (2.1.4.1)
zk  – scroll up (2.1.4.1)
zm  – align to middle horizontally (2.1.4.1)
zt  – align to top (2.1.4.1)
zz  – align to center (2.1.4.1)
|   – replace selection(s) with output (2.13)
~   – change case (2.6.6)
```